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Political highlights from the Climate Change and Business Conference

14 September 2026

Political leaders outlined contrasting approaches to climate policy at the 18th Climate Change and Business Conference in Auckland. The conference was jointly hosted by the Environmental Defence Society, the Sustainable Business Council and the Climate Leaders Coalition. The political session took the form of fireside chats and a recording is being released here (see link below).

Labour leader **Chris Hipkins** committed Labour to remaining in the Paris Agreement and to an immediate review of the Emissions Trading Scheme, addressing forestry offsets, whole-farm conversions and incentives for genuine emissions reductions. Labour would also develop a comprehensive energy strategy, reform the electricity market and oppose an LNG import terminal.

Climate Change Minister **Simon Watts** said remaining in Paris was a clear bottom line for National and defended the Climate Change Commission's advisory role. He emphasised the need for stability in the ETS, technology-led agricultural methane reductions and continued

electrification. He defended the proposed LNG facility as insurance against dry-year electricity shortages.

Green Party co-leader **Chlöe Swarbrick** advocated greater emphasis on domestic emissions reductions, an energy strategy and strengthening the independent role of the Climate Change Commission.

ACT leader **David Seymour** supported the ETS as an efficient mechanism but questioned New Zealand's Paris obligations and proposed abolishing the Commission, with its statutory functions returning to the responsible ministry.

New Zealand First's **Dr David Wilson** called for withdrawal from Paris, review of the Commission and structural electricity-market reform.

The Opportunity Party's **Qiulae Wong** announced a \$1 billion Industry Energy Resilience Fund, financed through a green bond backed by future ETS auction revenue, and argued for cross-party commitments on both mitigation and adaptation.

EDS CEO and moderator Gary Taylor noted that the clearest common ground was around energy security, increased renewable generation and the need for practical action on climate adaptation, although parties differed on how adaptation should be funded and delivered.

"There was significant, but not universal, support for a national energy strategy, retaining an independent Climate Change Commission and remaining in the Paris Agreement. While most parties recognised the importance of a credible ETS, they differed markedly on the need for further reform," Mr Taylor said.

The full version of the political session is available as a video via the link below.

More: Gary Taylor 021 895 896

<https://vimeo.com/1222583549>

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